

Desirability–Feasibility–Viability

The three lenses of human-centred innovation

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Every sustainable innovation must sit at the overlap of three lenses: **Desirability** (do people want it?), **Feasibility** (can we build it technically and operationally?) and **Viability** (can it sustain a business?). Design thinking deliberately starts from desirability, then reconciles the other two.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Associated with IDEO and its founders; popularised by Tim Brown as the balancing act at the heart of design thinking.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Innovation efforts fail when they optimise one lens — a delightful product nobody can afford to build, or a profitable idea nobody wants. The framework forces balance.

HOW IT IS USED

Teams score or interrogate a concept against all three lenses, surfacing which is weakest and needs work before commitment. It is often drawn as three overlapping circles.

WHEN IT IS USED

Concept screening, portfolio decisions and pitching, to test whether an idea is complete rather than merely attractive.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Product leaders, innovation managers, entrepreneurs and investors.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

By putting **desirability first**, it distinguishes human-centred design from purely technology- or finance-led innovation, and gives a shared decision language across functions.

FIGURE 1 · THREE LENSES, ONE SWEET SPOT

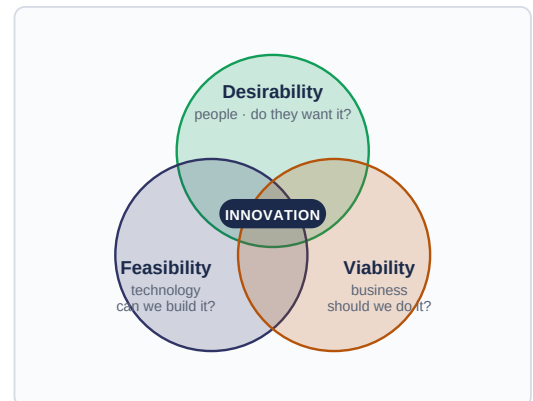


Figure 1. Innovation sits where what people want, what technology allows and what the business can sustain overlap.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

d.school 5-Stage Model *Slibrary 3*

Minimum Viable Product (MVP) *Slibrary 8*

Define Success *Slibrary 10*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Brown, T. (2009) *Change by Design*. New York: Harper Business.

IDEO (2015) *The Field Guide to Human-Centered Design*. San Francisco: IDEO.org.